PROLOGUE

A CURSE

'Severe punishment—that is, death', declared the judge on a cold February morning in Kabul. The courtroom, inhabited by a motley crowd of two hundred spectators keenly watching the proceedings of the war tribunal, erupted in joyful chants of 'Allah-u-Akbar'.[1] The year was 2006 and the Afghan judiciary had proved, in true Kafkaesque fashion, that it functioned just well enough to sentence a war criminal after nearly thirteen years of imprisonment and more than two decades after the crimes. Assadullah Sarwari became the first and only war criminal to be tried in Afghanistan. But death was not the worst that could happen to a man who had been in Afghan prisons for all these years. The most brutal twist of his life, in fact, had occurred in a friendly neighbouring country, but more on India later. Former spymaster, deputy prime minister (PM) of Afghanistan, vice president of the revolutionary council, and politburo member of the Khalq (people) faction of the left-wing *Hezb-e-Demokratik-e-Khalq-e-Afghanistan* or the People's Democratic Party of Afghanistan (PDPA), Sarwari had the blood of many Afghans on his hands. Thousands of people had disappeared, or were killed during his one-year tenure as Afghanistan's intelligence chief in 1978–79.[2] For instance, 4,785 Afghans were killed in the Pul-e-Charkhi prison on various charges of conspiring against the party.[3] Ambitious and cunning, Sarwari was at the forefront of a truly Byzantine political struggle. On one hand, he was fighting with a rival Marxist group within the PDPA, the Parcham (flag) faction. On the other hand, as part of the so-called